

Anthropomorphism

- Attributing human-like qualities to inanimate objects (e.g. cars, computers)
- Well known phenomenon in advertising
 - Dancing butter, drinks, breakfast cereals
- Much exploited in human-computer interaction
 - Make user experience more enjoyable, more motivating, make people feel at ease, reduce anxiety

Which do you prefer?

1. As a welcome message

- “Hello Chris! Nice to see you again. Welcome back. Now what were we doing last time? Oh yes, exercise 5. Let’s start again.”
- “User 24, commence exercise 5.”

Which do you prefer?

2. Feedback when get something wrong

1. *“Now Chris, that’s not right. You can do better than that. Try again.”*
2. *“Incorrect. Try again.”*

Is there a difference as to what you prefer depending on type of message? Why?

Evidence to support anthropomorphism

- Reeves and Naas (1996) found that computers that flatter and praise users in education software programs -> positive impact on them

“Your question makes an important and useful distinction. Great job!”

- Students were more willing to continue with exercises with this kind of feedback

Criticism of anthropomorphism

- Deceptive, make people feel anxious, inferior or stupid
- People tend not to like screen characters that wave their fingers at the user and say:
 - Now Chris, that's not right. You can do better than that. Try again."
- Many prefer the more impersonal:
 - "Incorrect. Try again."
- Studies have shown that personalized feedback is considered to be less honest and makes users feel less responsible for their actions (e.g. Quintanar, 1982)